Q+A

LEADING WITH THE LADIES

After directing hits like *Sangharsh* and *Qarib Qarib Singlle* for the big screen, filmmaker Tanuja Chandra has made her web debut with *Hush Hush*, a crime drama that premiered on Amazon Prime Video this week

Q. How would you describe your new series?
It's a contemporary crime drama, with fascinating female characters. This is an interesting time for women in our country. Each of us is struggling to balance modernity and progress with traditions and everything that's ritualistic. What got me interested was, of course, that it is a female-led story. The series format really allows you to explore in a layered way the relationships and lives of multiple women.

Q. What is it about streaming as a medium that makes it more welcoming to stories about women?
Unlike films, streaming shows don't have too much risk. The medium lends itself because we can genuinely stretch our imagination and explore the lives of women. I don't think cinema has the bandwidth to do this, maybe some indie films do, but it's not enough. Wanting to make a film with a woman at the centre of it continues to be a struggle.

Q. Among *Hush Hush*'s cast of incredible actors, both Juhi Chawla and Ayesha Julka are making their OTT debut...
This show was so much fun to cast because we have multiple protagonists and they are all of different ages. Soha (Ali Khan), Shahana (Goswami), Kritika (Kamra) and Karishma (Tanna) brought something really special to each of their characters. I had been wanting to work with Juhi for a long time. One has mostly seen her in fun, comical roles. I wanted to cast her in something dramatic. Ditto for Ayesha.

Q. Where do you stand on the debate around viewing habits?
I don't binge. I like to watch one episode, absorb it and be with it. And then the next day, watch the next. It's like reading a book. I like to feel close to it and be intimate.

–with Karishma Upadhyay



MANDAR DEODHAR